Avner Kantor, PhD

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Research Interests

Computational Social Science · Online Deliberation · Social Network Analysis · Data Journalism

Education

University of Haifa **2024**
PhD, Information & Knowledge Management *Haifa, Israel*

- Dissertation: *Online Deliberation and Data Journalism*
- Advisor: Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli

University of Haifa **2019**
MA (research track), Information & Knowledge Management *Haifa, Israel*

- Thesis: *Data Journalism, Transparency and Interactivity*
- Advisor: Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli

The Hebrew University of Jerusalem **2015**
MA, Philosophy Education *Jerusalem, Israel*

The Hebrew University of Jerusalem **2010**
BA, Philosophy; Teaching Certificate *Jerusalem, Israel*

Academic Positions

The Hebrew University of Jerusalem **2026–Present**
Guest Researcher, Federmann Center for the Study of Rationality (host: Prof. Ori Heffetz) *Jerusalem, Israel*

Reichman University (IDC Herzliya) **2021–2022**
Adjunct Lecturer, Lauder School of Government *Herzliya, Israel*

- Taught "Introduction to Data Science with Python for Government."

University of Haifa **2015–2018**
Research Fellow, Center for Internet Research *Haifa, Israel*

- Designed and launched *OpenPISA*, an open-data platform for the OECD PISA database.

Publications

Journal Articles

- **Kantor, A.**, & Rafaeli, S. (2026). Fewer but more elaborate: How information accessibility filters participation and shapes online news comments. *Journalism Studies*, 1–24. [DOI] [OSF]

Conference Proceedings

- **Kantor, A.**, & Rafaeli, S. (2025). Data, sense, and sensibility: How data journalism style shapes interactivity. *Selected Papers of Internet Research* (*AoIR*). [DOI] [OSF]
- **Kantor, A.**, & Rafaeli, S. (2025). Conversations with data: How data journalism affects online comments in the *New York Times*. *Proceedings of HICSS-58*, 8, 2386–2395. [ScholarSpace]
- **Kantor, A.**, & Rafaeli, S. (2021). Independence through data journalism. *Selected Papers of Internet Research* (*AoIR*). [DOI] [GitHub]
- **Kantor, A.**, & Rafaeli, S. (2020). Open PISA: Dashboard for large educational dataset. *Proceedings of the Seventh ACM Conference on Learning@Scale*, 253–256. [DOI] [opisa.org]

Submitted

- **Kantor, A.** Choosing content is choosing a mechanism: How information features shape who joins online discussions and how much they elaborate.

Working Papers

- **Kantor, A.** The narrative ratchet: Online information environments and the asymmetric adoption of inflation explanations.
- **Kantor, A.** The last mile: Information design after toxicity removal.
- **Kantor, A.** Open data that cannot be told: Essential statistical opacity in international assessments.
- **Kantor, A.** Diagnosing and guiding students' graph interpretations with a generative AI agent.
- **Kantor, A.**, Elbaz, Y., & Burk, L. Preserving growth rates in additive reconciliation of national accounts: A smoothed-Denton approach and the limits of weighting.

Applied Statistics

- Mor Shalom, M., **Kantor, A.**, et al. (2025). Changes in trends of visits and service utilization by mental health patients in the community: A twelve-year study in Israel. *Israel Journal of Health Policy Research*.
- Shapiro Ben David, S., **Kantor, A.**, et al. (2025). Reported penicillin allergy in Israel: Clinical outcomes and antibiotic costs in a nationwide population-based cohort study. *Journal of Allergy and Clinical Immunology: Global*.
- **Kantor, A.**, & Kantor, D. What are the odds, Dr. Quinn? Submitted.
- **Kantor, A.** One shot, twenty-one balls: Can a single stroke of snooker clear the whole table? Submitted. [GitHub]

Conferences Without Proceedings

- (August 2026) **Information Environments and the Structure of Political Discussion Networks.** Political Networks Conference, University of Manchester.

- (July 2026) **Beyond Who Shows Up: Information Design and Online Political Discourse.** "Elections in Times of Crisis" Conference, Israeli Political Science Association, Reichman University.
- (June 2026) **When Information Is Both Costly and Empowering: Equilibrium Selection Under Strategic Complementarities.** 42nd Annual Conference of the Israel Economic Association (IECA), Coller School of Management, Tel Aviv University.
- (May 2026) **The Architecture of Evidence: How Data Journalism Restructures the Topology of Online Deliberation.** COMPTEXT Conference, University of Birmingham.
- (2025) **Now You See Me: Using Generative AI to Drive Engagement with Data Visualizations.** IEEE VIS Workshop on GenAI, Vienna. (Poster).
- (2025) **Modeling How Data Journalism Shapes Discussion Networks.** Israel Statistics and Data Science Association (ISDSA). (Poster).
- (2020) **Does Data Journalism Engage Its Audience?** Computation + Journalism Symposium, Virtual Event.

Invited Talks & Seminars

- (2024) **Data journalism and learning analytics.** *Learning Analytics Café* MOOC (Prof. Ido Roll), Faculty of Education in Science and Technology, Technion.
- (2017) **Big data and citizen empowerment.** Public Policy and Politics in the Age of Media and Data, Open University of Israel.
- (2017) **Education data journalism.** The Israeli Visualization Conference, University of Haifa.
- (2017) **How can the public be encouraged to investigate educational questions?** Research Workshop of the Israel Science Foundation, Technion.
- (2017) **Education data journalism.** Open Media and Information Lab, Open University of Israel.
- (2015) **Data journalism.** Special Seminar for World Statistics Day, Israel Central Bureau of Statistics.

Professional Experience

Israel Central Bureau of Statistics (CBS) **2024–Present**
Statistician, Statistical Methodology Department *Jerusalem, Israel*

- Investigating the replacement of traditional official statistical methods with deep learning models to improve accuracy and efficiency.

Maccabi Health Services **2021–2024**
Data Scientist *Tel Aviv, Israel*

- Led research on physician burnout prediction and patient wait-time forecasting.
- Conducted high-impact retrospective cohort studies on COVID-19 and drug allergies, resulting in publications in top medical journals.

Corona National Information and Knowledge Center **2020–2021**
Data Scientist *Israel*

- Conducted rapid research on vaccine effectiveness and infection patterns to inform national policy.

Center for Educational Technology (CET) **2018–2020**
Data Scientist *Tel Aviv, Israel*

- Developed adaptive learning systems by integrating psychometric modeling (IRT) with machine learning algorithms.

Research Grants

- **Trump Family Foundation** (2015–2020): $120,000 for the Open PISA Project (PI: Prof. Sheizaf Rafaeli; co-investigator).
- **AllCloud Co.** (2017): $11,000 for cloud hosting support.
- **DAAD Center for German Studies** (2010–2011): $10,000 for "Narrative, Dreams, Imagination" (PI: Dr. Jen Glaser; co-investigator).

Service

Reviewer: International Communication Association (ICA); Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS); *Public Understanding of Science*; ACM CHI; ACM CSCW.